Wear Sunscreen: A Primer for Real Life

By Mary Schmich
(adapted by Baz Luhrmann)

INTRODUCTION

Mary Schmich's original column became a cultural phenomenon soon after it appeared. It was posted on Web pages and e-mailed to thousands of people as the text of novelist Kurt Vonnegut's commencement speech at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology. Unfortunately, Vonnegut had not delivered the speech at MIT. But the column went on to attract the notice of Australian movie director Baz Luhrmann. Luhrmann made the column the basis of a novelty song titled Everybody's Free (To Wear Sunscreen) on the album Something for Everybody , released in Australia in late 1997. Today I present this speech to you in it's original form, a witty and humorous take on the graduation speech we'd all like to make if given the opportunity. Wear Sunscreen by Mary Schmich.

Ladies and Gentlemen of the class of '99: Wear sunscreen.

If I could offer you only one tip for the future, sunscreen would be it. The long term benefits of

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sunscreen have been proved by scientists, whereas the rest of my advice has no basis more reliable than my own meandering experience.

I will dispense this advice now.

Enjoy the power and beauty of your youth; oh never mind; you will not understand the power and beauty of your youth until they've faded. But trust me, in 20 years you'll look back at photos of yourself and recall in a way you can't grasp now how much possibility lay before you and how fabulous you really looked. You're not as fat as you imagine.

Don't worry about the future; or worry, but know that worrying is as effective as trying to solve an algebra equation by chewing bubblegum. The real troubles in your life are apt to be things that never crossed your worried mind; the kind that blindside you at 4pm on some idle Tuesday.

Do one thing everyday that scares you.

Sing.

Don't be reckless with other people's hearts; don't put up with people who are reckless with yours.

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Floss.

Don't waste your time on jealousy; sometimes you're ahead; sometimes you're behind; the race is long, and in the end it's only with yourself.

Remember the compliments you receive; forget the insults. If you succeed in doing this, tell me how. Keep your old love letters; throw away your old bank statements.

Stretch.

Don't feel guilty if you don't know what to do with your life; the most interesting people I know didn't know at 22 what they wanted to do with their lives; some of the most interesting 40 year olds I know still don't.

Get plenty of calcium.

Be kind to your knees; you'll miss them when they're gone.

Maybe you'll marry -- maybe you won't. Maybe you'll have children -- maybe you won't. Maybe you'll divorce at 40 -- maybe you'll dance the funky chicken on your 75th wedding anniversary. Whatever you do, don't congratulate yourself too much or berate yourself

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either -- your choices are half chance; so are everybody else's.

Enjoy your body; use it every way you can. Don't be afraid of it, or what other people think of it. It's the greatest instrument you'll ever own.

Dance -- even if you have nowhere to do it but in your own living room.

Read the directions, even if you don't follow them.

Do NOT read beauty magazines; they will only make you feel ugly.

Get to know your parents; you'll never know when they'll be gone for good. Be nice to your siblings; they are the best link to your past and the people most likely to stick with you in the future.

Understand that friends come and go, but for the precious few you should hold on. Work hard to bridge the gaps in geography, in lifestyle, because the older you get the more you need the people you knew when you were young.

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Live in New York City once, but leave before it makes you hard;

Llve in Northern California once, but leave before it makes you soft.

Travel.

Accept certain inalienable truths: price will rise; politicians will philander; you too will get old, and when you do you'll fantasize that when you were young prices were reasonable, politicians were noble, and children respected their elders.

Respect your elders.

Don't expect anyone else to support you. Maybe you have a trust fund; maybe you have a wealthy spouse; but you never know when either one might run out.
Don't mess too much with your hair, or by the time you're 40, it will look 85.

Be careful who advice you buy, but be patient with those who supply it. Advice is a form of nostalgia: dispensing it is a way of fishing the past from the disposal, wiping it off, painting over the ugly parts, and recycling it for more than it's worth.

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But trust me on the sunscreen.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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